

FLAGSHIP SOLUTION SCALING TRACK PROFILE

Scaling Climate-Smart Agro-Advisories through the Shamba Shape Up Content Generation Platform

Scaling for Impact Science Program | Area of Work 2

Grand Challenge 1 · Close the Climate Adaptation Gap through Scalable Climate Services and Smart Water Management

Flagship 1.1 · Digital Climate Services for Resilient Farm & Enterprise Management

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Foreword

CGIAR SCALING FOR IMPACT · AREA OF WORK 2 — PATHWAYS TO SCALE IN AGRIFOOD SYSTEMS

CGIAR produces far more scale-ready innovation than currently reaches farmers at scale. Closing that gap is the purpose of the CGIAR Scaling for Impact (S4I) Science Program. Within S4I, Area of Work 2 — Pathways to Scale in Agrifood Systems — is organized around three Grand Challenges that mark where scaling can unlock the largest development returns across food, land, and water systems in a climate crisis. These Grand Challenges were defined through an evidence-led process — drawing on the CGIAR Impact Report 2022–2024, Initiative reporting, and an analysis of eleven major donor strategies — so that each rests on demonstrated scaling potential and connects directly to the priorities of CGIAR's funders.

Under each Grand Challenge sits a focused set of **Scaling Flagships** that "dock with" and support CGIAR's Science Programs — taking mature innovation bundles and accelerating their delivery and scaling systems:

- **Grand Challenge 1 — Close the Climate Adaptation Gap** through scalable climate services and smart water management

Flagship 1.1 — Digital Climate Services for Resilient Farm & Enterprise Management

Flagship 1.2 — Scaling Smart Irrigation & Climate-Resilient Water Systems

- **Grand Challenge 2 — Deliver Inputs and Services at Scale** through inclusive market systems

Flagship 2.1 — Scaling Resilient, Nutritious & Biodiverse Seed & Soil Systems

Flagship 2.2 — Entrepreneurship through Mechanization & Postharvest Services

Flagship 2.3 — Genetics, Inputs & Services for Animals & Aquaculture

- **Grand Challenge 3 — Drive Demand, Shape Behavior & Activate Policy** for nutrition

Flagship 3.1 — Catalyzing Demand for Nutritious Diets through Markets, Institutions & Policy

Each Flagship is delivered through **Scaling Solution Tracks** — the profile that follows is one of them. Tracks are run deliberately as large, time-bound scaling campaigns, not as research projects or pilots. Experience across the portfolio shows that the binding constraint to scaling is rarely the innovation itself; it is *system integration* — the delivery and business models, finance and risk-sharing, institutional and policy alignment, and coordination among actors required to move a proven solution into widespread use. Each track therefore bundles a validated innovation with a clear delivery pathway, committed partners, and a defined geography, and is driven through and with scaling partners rather than by CGIAR alone — leveraging complementary investments to amplify reach.

This campaign approach lets S4I concentrate resources, operate in performance-based mode against measurable KPIs — farmers adopting innovations, jobs created, consumers gaining access to healthier diets, and scaling finance and supportive policy mobilized — and hold itself accountable to the S4I 2030 outcome targets and CGIAR's Impact Area goals. Across every track, scaling is pursued responsibly and inclusively, with women, youth, and marginalized groups systematically included by design.

1. Overview

Millions of smallholder farmers across East and Southern Africa face a critical "pain point": they are increasingly vulnerable to climate variability but are cut off from the trusted, localized, and actionable advisory services they need to adapt. Traditional extension models are too costly and limited in reach to serve the millions of households at risk from climate shocks. Women and youth are often excluded. This scaling track directly addresses this challenge by transforming how CGIAR science reaches farmers, moving beyond pilots to achieve mass-scale impact.

The primary goal is to deliver climate-smart agro-advisories to 20 million households across Kenya, Zambia, Ethiopia, and Uganda by 2030. The solution is not a single piece of hardware or a seed variety, but a proven and powerful scaling partnership model. At its core is the Shamba Shape Up (SSU) platform, Africa's most trusted "farm makeover" edutainment show. This track will build a SSU Content Generation Platform to systematically translate CGIAR science into farmer-friendly narratives and disseminate them through a multi-channel delivery system spanning TV, radio, SMS, IVR, WhatsApp, YouTube, and the iShamba call center.

This model is ready to scale based on robust evidence. In Kenya, SSU reaches 9-10 million farmers and is the most trusted source of farming information for 90% of its viewers. A University of Reading study attributed a \$24 million net increase in dairy production value to practices adopted from the show. In Zambia, the Munda Makeover spinoff has reached 2.3 million people in just two years, with 67% of viewers reporting they have made farming changes as per the MMO Series II KAP (2024). This track, led by the Alliance of Bioversity International and CIAT in partnership with Mediae Company, will leverage this proven vehicle to broker and scale the best of CGIAR science.

2. Innovation Bundle and Scaling Ambition

This track scales a single, integrated innovation bundle: the SSU Content Generation Platform, a systematic mechanism for translating CGIAR science into trusted, farmer-facing edutainment and delivering it at mass scale through a multi-channel network. It is not a research product, a seed variety, or a standalone app. It is a proven brokerage and dissemination model that connects supply (CGIAR science) to demand (millions of smallholder farmers) through a channel farmers already trust.

The bundle has four interdependent components that function as a continuous loop:

- Content Generation Hub that curates, translates, and packages CGIAR science (seasonal forecasts, drought-tolerant varieties, soil and water management, improved crop and livestock practices) into accessible, narrative-driven edutainment segments. This is the engine that converts complex research into content farmers can watch, understand, and act on.
- A co-investment mechanism through which S4I matches contributions from other CGIAR Science Programs and private sector innovators, doubling the volume of climate-smart content produced. Every segment invested by a partner, S4I track will invest 2 segments in content on-screen. This is the fuel that keeps the engine running beyond S4I's direct funding and positions S4I as a catalyst for the broader CGIAR portfolio.
- Multi-Channel Delivery System like TV and radio broadcast (Citizen TV, ZNBC, and national broadcasters in Ethiopia) provides mass reach; SMS, IVR, WhatsApp, and YouTube deepen engagement for specific audiences; and the iShamba call centre provides personalized, two-way advisory follow-up. These channels are not alternatives; they are layered. TV creates awareness and trust; digital channels convert awareness into action.
- Farmer Feedback and Learning Loop through systematic KAP surveys, iShamba and iMunda call center analytics, and interactive audience polls capture what farmers learn, what they adopt, and where gaps

remain. This data feeds directly back into the Content Generation Hub, continuously improving content quality and relevance, and into CGIAR science pipelines to signal demand from the field.

These four elements are interdependent by design. The Challenge Fund feeds the Content Hub; the Hub produces content for the Multi-Channel Delivery System; iShamba deepens and tracks engagement; and the feedback loop connects outcomes back to content strategy. Removing any one component weakens the others.

2.1 Why This Bundle Is Ready to Scale

The SSU innovation has been validated in the CGIAR IPSR framework as a proven innovation ready for scaling. The evidence base is robust and spans over a decade:

- **Trust and reach:** 90% of Kenyan viewers identify SSU as their most trusted source of agricultural information outranking government extension officers, NGOs, and input dealers. The platform currently reaches 9–10 million farmers in Kenya and 2.3 million in Zambia through the Munda Makeover spin-off launched just two years ago.
- **Knowledge and adoption:** In Kenya, 96% of viewers report learning something new; 93% report making changes to their farming practices; and 63% of those who made changes report better yields and higher incomes (SSU KAP studies, Series 13–14). A University of Reading study (2014) estimated that 428,000 Kenyan households directly adopted new practices attributable to SSU, generating a net increase of over US\$24 million in dairy production value.
- **Zambia replicability:** In Zambia, the MMO Series II KAP (2024) shows about 67% of viewers adopted new practices and 70% of those who made changes reported measurable benefits, including higher crop yields. Amplified viewership grew from 1.9 million in Series I to 2.3 million in Series II, demonstrating growth momentum even in a new market.

Climate resilience: Pilots delivering La Niña seasonal forecast content in Zambia and Kenya demonstrated farmers' ability to reduce crop losses by adjusting planting decisions confirming that climate information delivered through this channel translates into on-farm adaptive action.

2.2 Scaling Targets

The ambition is transformational: to move CGIAR climate science from pilots to 20 million households across East and Southern Africa by 2030. The pathway is phased, funded, and grounded in what the evidence shows the platform can deliver.

Households Reached		10 million farmers (Kenya, Zambia)	20 million households (East and Southern Africa) by 2030; 16 million by 2028.
Farmers Adopting Climate-Smart Practices		Not specified, baseline to be established.	At least 40% of farmers reached adopt one or more climate-smart practices.
Content Co-Financing		Not specified, baseline to be established.	30% of operating costs covered through co-financing from governments and private partners.
Geographic Scope		Kenya, Zambia	Ethiopia, Uganda added; consolidation in Kenya and Zambia.

The 2026 milestone is not a start it is a consolidation and expansion of an already-operating platform. The challenge fund launches and the content generation hub developed. By 2028, the platform transitions from

externally funded to institutionally embedded, with adoption rates documented and co-financing targets on trajectory. By 2030, the system runs itself.

3. Scaling Pathway and Theory of Change

3.1 How Scale is Achieved

Scale in this track is not achieved by producing more content; it is achieved by building and operating a system that makes the production and delivery of quality, climate-smart content structurally inevitable. The pathway moves through three interlocking mechanisms: content is generated through the Hub and Challenge Fund; it is disseminated through a layered multi-channel system that meets farmers where they are; and it is progressively institutionalized into national systems, shifting the platform from donor-dependent to self-sustaining. Each mechanism directly addresses a specific constraint to scale.

Mechanism 1: Content as the Engine (from science to narrative)

The central bottleneck to scaling CGIAR climate science is not lack of knowledge it is the absence of a systematic, trusted process to translate that knowledge into formats farmers can act on. The Content Generation Hub addresses this directly. Embedded within Mediae Co., the Hub provides a structured interface between CGIAR science programs (supplying research on seasonal forecasts, drought-tolerant varieties, soil health, and pest management) and the SSU/MMO production pipeline.

The Challenge Fund This co-investment model positions S4I as a catalyst by matching every partner investment in two content segments, with two other segments making four segments aired. This creates a strong incentive for CGIAR Science Programs and private sector innovators to co-produce content. The online content library then archives all produced segments, creating a permanent, searchable repository of CGIAR-validated climate content accessible to broadcasters and extension services across the region.

Mechanism 2: Multi-Channel Delivery (from awareness to adoption)

The second bottleneck is the gap between reach and adoption. Farmers who watch the show need opportunities to deepen their learning, ask questions, and access the inputs required to act. The delivery system is designed to close this gap in layers:

TV and radio broadcast (Citizen TV, ZNBC) creates mass awareness and trust at scale reaching millions per episode at a fraction of the cost of traditional extension. For context, SSU delivers advisory content at cents per farmer, compared to dollars per farmer for conventional face-to-face extension. SMS, IVR, WhatsApp, and YouTube extend reach to farmers without TV access and allow for interactive follow-up particularly important for women who more frequently access content at home, and for youth who engage primarily through social media. The iShamba/iMunda call center provides the deepest layer: personalized, two-way advisory response to farmer queries, reinforcing what the show introduces and translating awareness into action. Roadshows in Zambia add a critical physical dimension, combining film screenings with temporary input marketplaces where farmers can immediately purchase the seeds, tools, or services shown on screen directly closing the input access gap.

Mechanism 3: Institutional Integration (from project to system)

The third and most fundamental bottleneck is sustainability. A platform that depends entirely on donor financing will not survive the end of a project cycle. The pathway therefore pursues active integration of SSU content and the edutainment model into national extension systems in each target country. This is not incidental it is the system change the track is designed to achieve. By securing formal MOUs with Ministries of Agriculture in Kenya, Zambia governments co-invest through in-kind contributions (studio time, technical experts, national broadcast airtime) and, over time, embed the platform into national extension budgets. In Kenya, this model is

already demonstrated: private sector contributions finance approximately 60% of production costs. Replicating this shift in Zambia is the explicit trajectory of this track.

3.2 Theory of Change If the Content Generation Hub and Challenge Fund systematically translate CGIAR climate science into trusted edutainment content, and if that content reaches smallholder farmers at scale through a layered multi-channel system that meets farmers where they are on TV, radio, SMS, IVR, WhatsApp, and in person at roadshows and if the iShamba/iMunda call center and farmer feedback loops ensure that content is responsive to what farmers need and that adoption barriers are addressed, and if Ministries of Agriculture and private sector partners progressively co-invest and institutionalize the delivery model into national extension systems, then farmers will adopt improved climate-smart practices, leading to increased resilience, productivity, and incomes, and ultimately agricultural extension in East and Southern Africa will shift from costly, donor-funded, government-delivered services to a self-sustaining, mass-media-anchored, public-private ecosystem that outlasts any single project.

4. Partners and Roles

The SSU Content Generation Platform scales through a partnership ecosystem in which every actor plays a defined, non-substitutable role in the pathway. The table below presents partners not as a stakeholder list but as functional agents each one directly addressing one or more of the bottlenecks identified in Section 3.

Demand Partners	Smallholder farmers, cooperatives, and SMEs across Kenya, Zambia, and Ethiopia. Agribusinesses (input providers, insurers, ICT companies, telecom operators).	End-users who adopt practices and drive demand. Co-investors who sponsor content and support roadshows to reach customers and validate solutions.
Scaling Partners	Production: Mediae Company. Dissemination: Citizen TV (Kenya), ZNBC (Zambia), and other national broadcasters. Government: Ministries of Agriculture and National Met Agencies in Kenya, Zambia, Ethiopia. CGIAR: Alliance Bioversity-CIAT, CIMMYT, IFPRI, IWMI, and Science Programs (CASP, Ukama Ustawi). Development: GEF, AICCR, FCDO, SDC, BMZ, FAO, UNDP.	Mediae produces the content. Broadcasters ensure mass-market reach. Governments provide technical expertise, co-financing, and integrate the model into national extension. CGIAR partners supply the scientific innovations. Development partners provide catalytic funding for specific themes or geographies.

4.1. Funding Model

S4I provides catalytic funding to establish the Content Generation Platform and Challenge Fund. Core production and dissemination costs are covered by a blended mix of private sector sponsorships, government co-financing (e.g., studio time, expert staff), and aligned donor projects (e.g., GEF, Soil and Water Accelerator), with the long-term goal of increasing the private sector share in new markets like Zambia.

5. Enabling Environment and Risks

5.1 Opportunities

- **High Government Demand:** Ministries of Agriculture in Kenya and Zambia have already demonstrated interest by contributing technical experts, viewing SSU as a cost-effective complement to public extension.
- **Private Sector Interest:** Agribusinesses see the platform as a uniquely effective way to reach millions of potential customers, creating a clear pathway for sustainable co-financing, as demonstrated by the ~60% private sector contribution in Kenya.
- **Proven Replicability:** The successful launch and rapid growth of Munda Makeover in Zambia proves the model can be adapted and scaled across different country contexts.
- **Trusted Platform:** SSU's established reputation as a trusted source of information creates a strong foundation for introducing new, complex CGIAR innovations.

5.2 Challenges and Mitigation

- **Financial Sustainability in New Geos:** Zambia's model is still heavily donor-funded, unlike Kenya's.
- **Mitigation:** The Challenge Fund is designed to attract private sector co-investment from the outset in new countries. The goal is to accelerate the path to a 60/40 private/public blend seen in Kenya.
- **Access to Inputs:** Farmers may not be able to adopt practices if recommended inputs (e.g., drought-tolerant seeds) are unavailable locally.
- **Mitigation:** Integration of "roadshow" models that create temporary marketplaces, and fostering partnerships with private sector agro-dealers to ensure last-mile distribution.
- **Reach vs. Adoption:** The focus can remain on the number of viewers ("reach") rather than on measurable behavior change and impact.
- **Mitigation:** Deep investment in MELIA, including longitudinal analysis of KAP data and plans for more rigorous evaluations (e.g., with AoW5), to track adoption of specific practices and understand drivers and barriers.
- **Inclusion Risks:** Women, youth, and those without TVs may be underserved by a primarily visual medium.
- **Mitigation:** Dedicated gender-transformative content using Gender-Up principles, diversification into radio and low-literacy channels like IVR, and creation of short-form content for social media to engage youth.

6. Learning and Adaptation

Learning in this track is not a reporting requirement it is a structural feature of the scaling pathway. This section describes the evidence architecture that makes those decisions possible, and the adaptation logic that connects evidence to action.

What We Are Trying to Learn

The monitoring framework is organized around four questions, each linked directly to a bottleneck identified in Sections 3.

- **Adoption drivers:** Which practices achieve durable adoption and what distinguishes them from those that don't? What role does input access, behavior change complexity, or channel format play? This question addresses the residual risk that reach metrics mask low adoption, and its answer determines where content investment is most productive. For example, MMO Series II data showed that irrigation learning was high

among viewers but uptake remained constrained by water access a finding that should directly shape both content design (pairing irrigation episodes with solar pump marketplaces at roadshows) and Challenge Fund calls (prioritizing content partners who can address input availability, not just awareness).

- **Channel effectiveness:** How do TV, radio, SMS, IVR, roadshows, and social media reels compare in driving awareness and adoption for different practices and different demographic groups? This question addresses the bottleneck of women and youth being underserved by a primarily TV-delivered system, and its answer informs how to allocate investment across channels as the platform expands into new geographies with different media access profiles.

Reach-to-adoption conversion: What is the rate from viewing a practice to trying it to sustaining it? How do bundled multi-channel interventions perform against single-channel approaches? This question addresses the core evidence gap that current KAP data measures claimed rather than verified adoption and its answer is essential for demonstrating to government ministries and private sector co-investors that the platform delivers outcomes, not just audiences.

- **Inclusivity:** Are gender and youth-sensitive content and channels reaching and converting these target groups, not just counting them? This connects directly to the GenderUp commitments in Section 3's Responsible Scaling sub-section and to the inclusion targets (30% women, 20% youth) set in Section 2's targets table.

Adaptation Logic: What Changes Based on What We Learn

The adaptation cycle operates at three distinct tempos so that learning translates into decisions, not documentation.

- **Annual (strategic):** End-line KAP findings and the 2026 longitudinal analysis of 15+ seasons of SSU/MMO data directly shape the content brief for the following series and the Challenge Fund call for proposals. If data shows high awareness but low adoption for a specific practice, the next series brief pairs that practice with a corresponding input access solution a roadshow marketplace, an agro-dealer partnership, or an SMS input-sourcing service. If a topic consistently shows low viewer interest or knowledge lift, it is reformatted or deprioritized. The longitudinal analysis will also generate the country-specific baseline intelligence needed for the Ethiopia entry, so that scaling into a new context is grounded in what the data reveals about adoption drivers rather than assumed to replicate automatically.
- **Quarterly (operational):** iShamba/iMunda intelligence briefs are reviewed at quarterly S4I progress sessions alongside Challenge Fund contribution data and audience measurement reports. These are decision-making moments, not reporting occasions. The questions asked are concrete: Is the Challenge Fund attracting the right partners? Are there content gaps emerging from call data that the current series is not addressing? Are co-financing baselines in Zambia being documented on schedule? Findings are captured in a brief update to the work plan for the following quarter, ensuring that emerging evidence influences the production cycle before the next series locks its content brief.
- **Continuous (real-time):** iShamba/iMunda call center staff flag unusual patterns a spike in pest queries, a surge of questions about a weather event not covered in broadcast to the Content Hub coordinator within the week. Short-form responses via SMS alerts, WhatsApp messages, or YouTube reels can be deployed within days. This is the operational expression of the feedback loop described in the innovation bundle: the platform acts as a near-real-time advisory service, not a once-a-week broadcast. It also generates the real-time signal that allows the track to adapt content to climate events as they unfold — which is precisely the climate information bottleneck the track is designed to address.
- **Strengthening evidence rigor over time:** The track will explore collaboration with AoW5's Dynamic Learning Agenda to design more rigorous evaluation cycles, including A/B testing of message formats via iShamba/iMunda SMS and structured comparisons of roadshow versus non-roadshow adoption rates. Where feasible, third-party verification of adoption claims will be pursued for high-value practices such as

conservation agriculture, directly addressing the self-reporting limitation in current KAP methodology. This progressive strengthening of the evidence base serves two purposes: it improves content quality decisions internally, and it builds the body of independently verified impact evidence needed to sustain government and private sector co-financing commitments through the 2028 institutionalization phase and beyond.

7. Next Steps and Timeline (2026)

Quarter	Key Activities
Q1	Finalize S4I work plan and budget. Begin consolidation and longitudinal analysis of historical KAP data. Initiate design and governance structure for the Content Generation Platform and Challenge Fund. Launch call for Challenge Fund proposals focused on other S4I scaling tracks.
Q2	First Challenge Fund window closes; selected content segments go into production with Mediae Co. Development of the online content library begins. Broadcast of new, co-funded segments in Kenya and Zambia. Baseline KAP surveys conducted for the 2026 season.
Q3	Continued broadcast and dissemination of content via all channels (TV, radio, social media). Mid-year review of progress and learning with S4I team. Policy engagement workshops with Ministry of Agriculture stakeholders in Ethiopia to plan for entry.
Q4	End-line KAP surveys conducted. Analysis and documentation of 2026 learnings, including Challenge Fund outcomes. Develop detailed expansion plan for Ethiopia and Uganda for 2027. Share results and success stories with S4I and broader CGIAR audience.

8. Communications and Knowledge

Key products will include policy briefs on cost-effective extension, learning briefs on adoption drivers from the longitudinal data analysis, and success stories featuring farmers and the new innovations scaled through the Challenge Fund.

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